



GEARING UP!
The Lankan Army

The Going Gets Rough

As political temperatures rise in India, Sri Lanka remains reluctant to end a campaign it feels has cornered the LTTE

■ **By Christine Jayasinghe
in Colombo**

Undeterred by strong censure from India, Sri Lankan President Mahinda Rajapakse is going ahead with his military campaign to rout the Tamil Tigers and take over territory in the island's north that has long been in their grasp. Despite New Delhi's strong public statements expressing concern over the fallout of Rajapakse's war on the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), the defence ministry continues to announce details of troop advances and casualty figures in the neighbourhood. Rajapakse has

taken pains to stress that India has not asked him to suspend the battle, obviously well aware of the fact that India's ruling Congress party has to balance the sentiments of regional Tamil politicians with its inability to call for an end to the anti-LTTE operation.

Despite such declarations, not everything seems to be all right. Last week, Sri Lanka decided to send a delegation of legislators to India. Later it changed plans and decided to dispatch Basil Rajapakse, the president's brother and the main political strategist, to India for defusing the increased tension. Meanwhile, as pressure from the ruling DMK in Tamil Nadu

continued to mount, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee made a suo moto statement in Parliament expressing his "serious concern" at the deteriorating humanitarian situation in northern Sri Lanka, and saying that the rights and welfare of Sri Lankan Tamils should not get "enmeshed in the ongoing hostilities against the LTTE".

The sudden friction was provoked by the Indian Tamil politicians, led by the DMK, who charged that the civilians in the neighbourhood were being targeted. Their concern stemmed from the fact that a number of Sri Lankan Tamil refugees were landing in south India and from reports of thousands of people fleeing from their homes in the island's northern Wanni districts. The situation worsened